WEEK 8 · LECTURE L2 OF 3 · UNIT III

Storytelling with Data and the Ethics of Framing

From chart to decision, and how a true chart can still mislead.

Part 1	From chart to decision: a narrative for a data argument
Part 2	How framing misleads; honest visualization
Part 3	Exercise: one true, decision-ready story from GreenLeaf data
Read	Knaflic (2015); Angrave et al. (2016)

R K Singh · Senior Professor, Department of Commerce · Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi · DSEH001 · M.Com. PGCF 2025

PART 1 · THREE ACTS

Setup, conflict, resolution

Setup

The question and the current state. What?

Conflict

The gap the data reveal. So what?

Resolution

The evidence-based action. Now what?

Message	Chart
Comparison	Bar or column
Trend	Line
Relationship	Scatter
Distribution	Histogram or box plot

PART 2 · FRAMING

Same exits, two accurate stories

Department	Exits (count)	Exit rate
Store Operations	91	22.5%
IT and Technology	17	33.3%
Corporate HR	8	13.1%

THE POINT

Counts point at Store Operations; rates point at IT. Both are true. An honest chart says which it shows and why. Source: Employee_Master, Department and Attrition_Flag.

PART 2 · HONEST VISUALS

Three ways a true chart misleads

Cherry-picking

Showing only the time window or segment that supports the story. Show limits and contrary evidence.

Misleading scales

Truncated axes, uneven intervals, 3D. Start bars at zero.

Hidden uncertainty

A sample figure presented as exact. Show ranges and sample sizes.

EXERCISE

Tell one true, decision-ready story from GreenLeaf data in three sentences: what, so what, now what.

Going deeper: the theory underneath data storytelling

The next slides set out Knaflic's six lessons, Tversky and Kahneman on framing, Heath and Heath on sticky ideas, and Huff's warnings: what each claims, how it works, where it breaks, and what it means at GreenLeaf.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KNAFLIC (2015)

Six lessons for a data story

THE CORE IDEA

Understand the context, choose the right visual, eliminate clutter, focus attention, think like a designer, tell a story.

HOW IT WORKS

Start from the audience and the action you want, then design backward to the chart.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

A practitioner guide; it rests on design experience more than experiments.

AT GREENLEAF

Round 5 asked for a headline, three metrics and a counter metric: Knaflic's discipline in miniature.

THEORY IN DEPTH · TVERSKY AND KAHNEMAN (1981)

The same facts, framed differently, change choices

THE CORE IDEA

In the Asian disease problem, people preferred a program framed as lives saved over the same program framed as deaths.

HOW IT WORKS

Gains invite caution; losses invite risk-taking. The frame shifts the reference point.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Effect sizes vary, and expert audiences are not immune.

AT GREENLEAF

"79% of staff stayed" and "21% of staff left" are the same fact but invite different Board responses.

THEORY IN DEPTH · HEATH AND HEATH (2007)

Ideas stick when they are simple and concrete

THE CORE IDEA

SUCCESs: Simple, Unexpected, Concrete, Credible, Emotional, Stories.

HOW IT WORKS

A concrete case and an unexpected fact carry an abstract number into memory.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Stickiness serves bad ideas too; it is a tool, not a test of truth.

AT GREENLEAF

Lakshmi's 32% POSH score is a concrete story that makes the Tier 3 completion gap stick.

THEORY IN DEPTH · HUFF (1954)

How to lie with statistics

THE CORE IDEA

A classic catalogue of the tricks: biased samples, well-chosen averages, missing figures, gee-whiz graphs.

HOW IT WORKS

Ask: who says so, how do they know, what is missing, did someone change the subject, does it make sense?

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Old examples, but the five questions remain a sound checklist.

AT GREENLEAF Apply Huff's five questions to every vendor claim about adoption or ROI.

TAKEAWAYS

Three things to carry out of this lecture

1

Every data story needs what, so what and now what.

2

Say whether you show counts or rates, and why.

3

An honest chart shows its limits.

NEXT KPI frameworks and building a data culture.